

BLESSED BUT BARREN

(1 Samuel 1:1-5 NKJV)

“1 ¶ Now there was a certain man of Ramathaim Zophim, of the mountains of Ephraim, and his name [was] Elkanah the son of Jeroham, the son of Elihu, the son of Tohu, the son of Zuph, an Ephraimite. 2 And he had two wives: the name of one [was] Hannah, and the name of the other Peninnah. Peninnah had children, but Hannah had no children. 3 This man went up from his city yearly to worship and sacrifice to the LORD of hosts in Shiloh. Also the two sons of Eli, Hophni and Phinehas, the priests of the LORD, [were] there. 4 And whenever the time came for Elkanah to make an offering, he would give portions to Peninnah his wife and to all her sons and daughters. 5 But to Hannah he would give a double portion, for he loved Hannah, although the LORD had closed her womb.”

INTRO: This is a familiar story in the Old Testament. It is the story of how Samuel was born. He was one of the greatest prophets who ever lived.

It is an interesting account in that Elkanah had two wives. This was not uncommon for that day. A man with more than one wife usually spoke of wealth. From all the accounts I see in the Bible, multiple wives usually meant multiple problems... (Sarah & Hagar, Leah & Rachel...)

The main character of this story is Hannah. The word Hannah in the Hebrew is Channah *khan-naw* which means “Grace”. She is the “Graced one...” But the scripture says she is BARREN...

Look at this account... Elkanah LOVED Hannah more than Peninnah... When giving out gifts, he gave Hannah a “double portion”.... IN FRONT OF PENINNAH... This is not a “private blessing”. You are never so blessed as you are when God blessed you in front of your enemies... “He prepares a table for me in the presence of my enemies...”

v. 5 - BUT...THE LORD HAD SHUT UP HER WOMB (KJV)

I. THE ISSUE OF HER BARRENNESS

A The only way a woman in Bible days could participate in covenant was to have children. The covenant was made to Abraham and “his seed” and the part the woman played in this covenant was to produce that seed... to have children, and especially a MAN CHILD... Hannah was not being fulfilled in her PURPOSE...

B Having children was also a token of an intimate relationship with her husband. You knew if a woman was having children she was being intimate with her husband...

We know the story, Elkanah loved Hannah more than Peninnah, but that is not what people saw... When they saw Peninnah walk by with all her children and Hannah with no children, they assumed that Elkanah was spending all his time with Peninnah and shunning Hannah.

C Hannah has a relationship with Elkanah, but no fruit of that relationship. She was NOT PRODUCTIVE...

D. Everybody has an issue... Hannah is favored and loved and has a “double portion”... BUT... she is barren.

E. PEOPLE WITH ISSUES...

1) NAAMAN - “Now Naaman, captain of the host of the king of Syria, was a great man with his master, and honourable, because by him the LORD had given deliverance unto Syria: he was also a mighty man in valour, **[but he was] a leper.**” (2 Kings 5:1 AV)

2) JOSEPH OF ARIMATHEA- “And after this Joseph of Arimathaea, being a disciple of Jesus, **but secretly for fear of the Jews**, besought Pilate that he might take the body of Jesus: and Pilate gave [him] leave. He came therefore, and took the body of Jesus.” (John 19:38 AV)

away

3) DAVID - A man after God’s own heart, greatest earthy king of all time... BUT ONE NIGHT ON A ROOFTOP...

4) PETER - Upon this rock I will build my church... BUT ONE NIGHT IN A COURTYARD...

5) Man is the Synagogue, BUT HAD A WITHERED HAND...

F. We all have ISSUES, but God doesn’t wait until we have all our issues worked out before He will bless us... HANNAH IS BARREN... BUT BLESSED...

II. THE PURPOSE OF HER BARRENNESS (1 Samuel 1:5b AV)

“... but the LORD had shut up her womb.”

A. THE LORD - Some people in the world who are barren are so because of a physical problem, but the barrenness here is caused BY GOD...

B. When God shut up a womb, it was for a purpose...

- 1) Sarah - bare Isaac, the child of promise to Abraham
- 2) Rebekah - bare Jacob and Esau
- 3) Rachel - bare Joseph...

C. All of these women have something in common with Hannah...
when they did bare a child... it was a CHILD OF PURPOSE...

Almost anybody can produce a baby, but not everybody can give birth to a purpose...

ILL: Peninnah is having children left and right... CAN YOU
NAME ONE OF THEM?

D. Hannah was not ready to bring forth the magnitude of what God
has planned for her. When God wants to bring forth His purpose in your
life, HE WANTS ALL THE CREDIT...

God allowed Hannah to be barren until she came to the place she
was willing to give to God whatever He gave to her...

ILL: When Peninnah brought forth children she flaunted it as
what she had done... When Hannah brought forth her son, she
and everyone else had to say... LOOK WHAT THE LORD HAS
DONE...

III. THE PROVOKING OF HER BARRENNESS

(1 Samuel 1:6 AV)

*"And her adversary also provoked her sore, for to make her fret, because the
LORD had shut up her womb."*

A. In verse 6 it repeats what verse 5 had already said... THE LORD
HAD SHUT UP HER WOMB. But there is an added Hebrew
word in verse 6 that does not show up in the English
translation... b@'ad *beh-ad*' - which means "round about".
Literally this would say, "The Lord had shut up AROUND her
womb..."

In other words her womb is shut up from every angle. EVERY
DOOR IS CLOSED...

B. HER ADVERSARY - Peninnah is provoking... She is an agent
of God. We all have a Peninnah.

When you are as blessed as Hannah is blessed it is easy to become comfortable and forget about our barrenness. Peninnah is there to constantly remind Hannah that she is barren...

- C. If it were not for certain provoking agents in our lives, WE WOULD NOT PRODUCE...

Elkanah is not this agent... He says, "Aren't I better to you than 10 sons..."

God sends some people into our lives to PROVOKE US... So we will not stop praying for those things to come to pass in our lives...

- D. Peninnah is there to STIR UP HANNAH.

(2 Timothy 1:6 AV)

"Wherefore I put thee in remembrance that thou stir up the gift of God, which is in thee by the putting on of my hands."

- E. Whatever keeps you from becoming COMFORTABLE in your barrenness, you ought to thank God for...

CONC: THE END OF HER BARRENNESS

- A. In verse 6, when Peninnah provokes Hannah, the scripture says it is to make her FRET... That word in the Hebrew is ra'am *raw-am* which means "To Thunder".

THUNDER is a result or reaction to LIGHTNING...

LIGHTNING - the flashing of light produced by a discharge of atmospheric electricity...

- B. Through Peninnah the Lord is getting Hannah to a place where she will realize that THINGS ARE CHANGING IN THE ATMOSPHERE. Things are becoming aligned. There is about to be a release of POWER and ANOINTING... God wants Hannah to respond to that.

- C. It is not enough that God is changing the atmosphere and setting us up for something great in our lives... WE HAVE TO THUNDER...

Hannah said... I am not eating any more... I am going to the temple... I will pray... I will vow a vow... Her response is silent... They think she is drunk... She can only groan and

moan... SHE IS THUNDERING...

(1 Samuel 1:17-20 AV)

*"17 Then Eli answered and said, Go in peace: and the God of
Israel grant [thee] thy petition that thou hast asked of him. 18
And she said, Let thine handmaid find grace in thy sight. So the
woman went her way, and did eat, and her countenance was no more
[sad]. 19 ¶ And they rose up in the morning early, and worshipped
before the LORD, and returned, and came to their house to Ramah: and
Elkanah knew Hannah his wife; and the LORD remembered her. 20
Wherefore it came to pass, when the time was come about after Hannah had
conceived, that she bare a son, and called his name Samuel, [saying],
Because I have asked him of the LORD."*